

LOGGED Out

Delving deep into the scandal, nailing the truth and finding a suitor for Satyam is a long chase

| By Amarnath K. Menon |

Last week, sleuths of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probing the Rs 7,136-crore Satyam con hit a technical hurdle. Wading through millions of bytes stored in hard disks of computers is hard enough. But the officers discovered that the conspirators of the con had deployed biometric entry barriers at different levels to prevent entry into databases. In a sense the sleuths rediscovered the relevance of fingerprints. Delicately and discreetly, they moved the conspirators—Byrraju Ramalinga Raju, his brother and Satyam Computer Services co-founder B. Rama Raju and ex-CFO Srinivas Vadlamani—to different buildings hosting the offices of Satyam and got them to log in so that they could unravel the maze that hides the single-most important answer: where did all that money go?

The answers are not easily available even though CBI officials have seized and sealed computers and servers hoarding millions of bytes of information. Nearly 75 days after the arrest of Raju, the only thing that investigations have unravelled is that the maze is far deeper than they thought. Barely a fortnight remains for the expiry of the mandatory 90-day period to file the preliminary chargesheet and it is unlikely to reveal much

of what happened. Though the Raju brothers were arrested on January 10 and Vadlamani a couple of days later, investigations into the allegations and charges have not kept pace for the authorities to list them vividly in a chargesheet by April 9.

Even as suitors line up for control of what used to be the fourth-largest software company in India, investigators are struggling to piece the evidence together. It doesn't help that there are multiple agencies involved—the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) of the Andhra Pradesh Police, Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), Serious Fraud Investigation Office, (SFIO) Enforcement Directorate, (ED), Income Tax (I-T) authorities and CBI—and that the investigations had to be started afresh after CBI took over from the CID on February 18 on a state government request. Sure, the investigators have found many valuable leads in accounting fraud and financial malfeasance to make substantial progress, but there is not enough to give a clear picture of who scammed who and how.

It is now a totally fresh case under a new First Information Report (FIR) and, therefore, as the specially constituted Multi-Disciplinary Investigation Team (MDIT) of the CBI keeps approaching a specially designated court, the country's premier investigation agency is left with



RAJU, WHO SCRIPTED THE RS 7136-CRORE SATYAM CON, AT A HYDERABAD COURT

no option but to ask for more time to frame supplementary charge-sheets after extensive investigations, seeking refuge under the special law governing its functioning. Predictably, the delays are adding fuel to theories of a political conspiracy. The buzz in Hyderabad is: nothing before the polls are over.

INDIA TODAY enquiries with the different probing agencies show that though the Raju brothers have perpetrated what the 14th Additional Chief Metropolitan Magistrate, Hyderabad, N. Victor Immanuel described as "the rarest of rare cases of fraud, which merited categorising as exceptional". Immanuel is also the presiding officer of the designated court for CBI cases.

Though the CID is ill-equipped to probe a financial scandal of such large magnitude for want of expertise, it managed to seize a wealth of data and that has enabled the CBI to put together